SPARKY'S SCIENCE FACTS

How Does Your Heart Work?

Biology · Ages 7+

> **Short answer:** Your heart is a strong muscle about the size of your fist. It pumps blood all around your body, all day and all night.

How it works

- Each beat squeezes blood into tubes called arteries, which carry it to every part of you.
- Blood carries oxygen from your lungs and food from your meal to all your cells.
- Veins bring the blood back to the heart, and it goes to the lungs to collect fresh oxygen.
- A child's heart beats about 70 to 100 times a minute when resting, and faster when you run.

Key words: Pulse: the beat you feel in your wrist or neck; Arteries and veins: blood's roads

Common mix-ups

- Blood is never blue. Blood in veins is dark red; veins only look blue through your skin.
- Your heart is not on the far left of your chest: it is in the middle, tilted a little left.

Did you know? The first human heart transplant was done in Cape Town in 1967, by Dr Chris Barnard at Groote Schuur Hospital.

Try it: Put two fingers on your wrist and count the beats for 15 seconds, then times 4. Jump for a minute and count again!

Ask Sparky: Why does my heart beat faster when I run? What is blood made of?